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PART I: ACCESS TO INFORMATION FROM WRITTEN TEXTS

(70 points)

Read the article below and then answer questions 1-7.

A glossary of the underlined words (numbers 1-10) is provided on page 5.

PEOPLE AGAINST PLASTIC

I Much of our world – including most of our clothes, toys, furniture, and more than 50% of cars and planes – is made of some type of plastic. However, this cheap, light, strong material also has serious disadvantages: when it is thrown away, it becomes a major part of all the garbage we produce. Moreover, it takes hundreds of years to decompose¹, creating problems for the environment. Recently, the public has become more aware of these problems. Consequently, there is an increasing demand² to greatly reduce the use of plastic.

II These days, you often hear people criticize the use of plastic cups and straws³ in cafés, or see shoppers bringing their own bags from home. You may also have heard of the activities of protest groups worldwide. Groups in the USA and South Korea, for example, left huge quantities of plastic from unnecessary packaging⁴ outside supermarkets. Governments are beginning to respond to such protests. About fifty countries have made it illegal to provide shoppers with plastic bags. One hundred other countries require these bags to be made of a special plastic that decomposes quickly. Furthermore, some manufacturers now make their products out of natural materials instead of plastic.

III All of this has come as a surprise to environmental scientists. "We've been warning the public about plastic for more than thirty years. But people were never as worried as they are now," says Anna Lewin, an ocean scientist at Sunport University. Lewin believes that the change began when people first learned what happened with microbeads – tiny pieces of plastic that were added to face creams and cleaning products. After use, microbeads were washed away⁵ from homes into the oceans, where scientists have found them in many kinds of fish. They were also recently discovered in ordinary drinking water, and experts began to worry that high levels might harm humans⁶ as well as animals.

IV When news of this danger spread⁷ through the media⁸, public protests were seen immediately throughout the world. As a result, many governments introduced laws banning⁹ the use of microbeads. "This really helped people realize how much power they have," says Lewin. "So now they are using this power to target¹⁰ all forms of plastic. And governments and companies are listening."